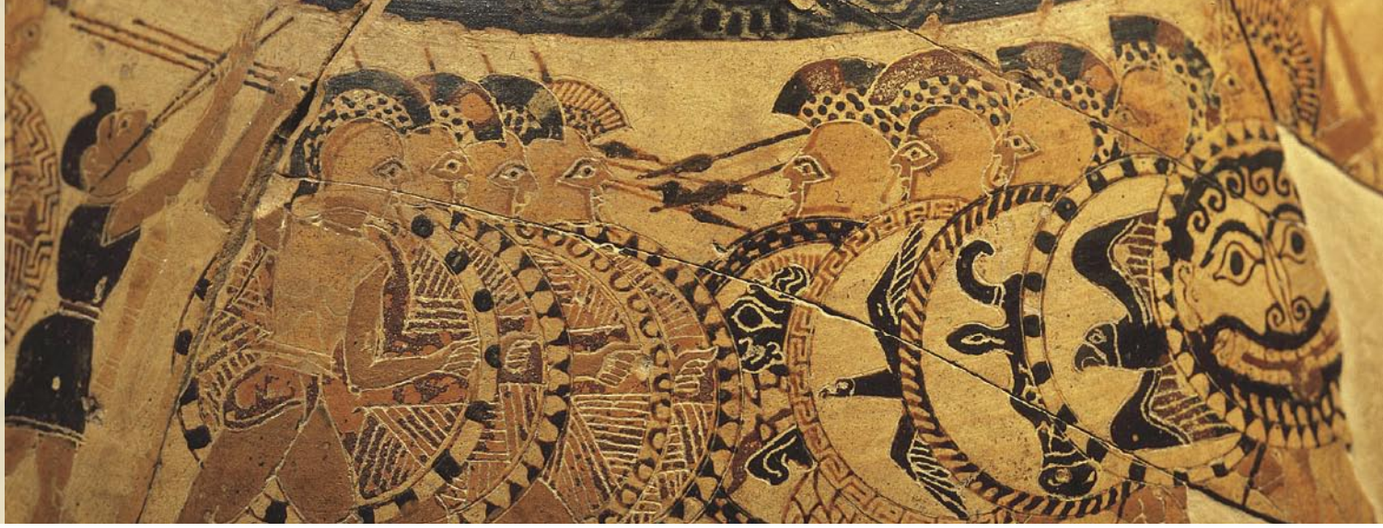


Phalanx meets phalanx
Ancient Greek warfare was highly symmetrical. When two phalanxes clashed, each presented exactly the same wall of shields topped by a bristling row of spears. On the left, a musician with a double flute plays a Spartan-style war song to keep up the spirit of the advancing hoplites.

By contrast, Sparta was a totally militarized state. The Spartan citizens, who were probably many fewer in number than the Athenians, relied on a large population of non-citizen labourers – the helots. These were essentially serfs that belonged to the state and, as such, posed a much greater threat to the security of the Spartan regime than did the slaves owned by individual Athenians. That all Sparta's male citizens were raised to be soldiers was partly through fear of a helot revolt.

SPARTAN UPBRINGING

Young Spartans were subjected to a rigorous system of military training and bonding. Male children were toughened up by exposure to the elements – they went barefoot and lightly clad through the winters – and punishments for failing tests of initiative and daring. At the age of 20, they were assigned to a barracks where they ate and slept, kept apart from women, for the following ten years. It was a system designed to create a disciplined fighting force, and it seems to have succeeded. The Spartans marched to battle in step to music, a skill that was quite beyond the Athenians. They had a coherent chain of command and could carry out relatively complex battlefield manoeuvres without losing formation.

GREEK VERSUS GREEK

Campaigns fought by city-state citizen armies were of necessity short, usually restricted to the summer season. There was no proper supply system to maintain an army in the field, although large numbers of slaves – or, in the case of the Spartans, helots – accompanied an army on its march to meet the enemy, and foraging and preparing food would have been an important part of their duties. A military campaign often came to an end simply because most of the soldiers on both sides were farmers who had to go home to their fields to harvest their crops.

When city-state armies met, they first made sacrifices to the gods and then drew up in phalanxes facing one another, choosing the most level piece of ground available – phalanx tactics did not work well on rough terrain. The most experienced fighters were placed in the front three rows of the phalanx and in the back row, where it was their job to deter weaker spirits from attempting to run away. A crowd of skirmishing troops, many of them probably the personal slaves of the hoplites, operated around the phalanxes, harassing the enemy with a deluge of stones, javelins, and arrows. The advance of an armoured phalanx to contact – each man



Cooking on campaign
The Greeks made portable earthenware cooking stoves that were fuelled by charcoal. These may well have been used by Greek armies on the march.

GREEK NAVAL WARFARE



The Greeks were famed for their skill at naval warfare, using the light, fast warships known as triremes. Each trireme was run by a captain, or "trierach". In Athens trierarchs were appointed from among those who owned "land and a house" in the city. It was the captain's responsibility to recruit and pay a crew, the majority of whom were oarsmen. Since a fleet of 100 ships might be assembled for a campaign, it was hard to find sufficient recruits. Most triremes went to sea with a mix of paid citizens, foreign mercenaries, and slaves at the oars. A trireme also typically carried ten armoured marines and four archers.

Trireme
It took 170 men to crew the oars of a trireme and synchronizing the strokes was not easy, as volunteers aboard the reconstructed trireme *Olympias* discover.

A trireme was extremely cramped. There was room only for three days' supply of food and water. Crews usually went ashore to eat at midday and at nightfall to sleep. Much time was spent foraging for food and drink, unless the war fleet was supported by supply vessels.

The trireme had a heavy bronze ram at its prow. In battle, ships manoeuvred around one another, attempting to ram an enemy in the flank. Meanwhile the marines and archers rained missiles upon the enemy – the marines threw their javelins from a seated position, to avoid unbalancing the ship. A trireme with a skilled helmsman and a disciplined crew could ram an enemy vessel or ride over its oars and then reverse, leaving it crippled in the water. Alternatively, the marines would board the rammed vessel, seizing it after hand-to-hand fighting with spears and axes.